- It tells esbuild to `--bundle`, meaning create a file with all dependencies and transitive dependencies of the top-level targets contained inline. esbuild will create a separate bundled file for each target matched in the input list. Again, we only have one of those files at the moment. Individual dependency files will be bundled according to how esbuild is set up to handle that file type.

- It tells esbuild to `--sourcemap`, creating a source map file for each bundle. The source map allows the browser developer tools to connect lines in the bundle to lines in our original source, even if esbuild has also converted the file from TypeScript to JavaScript.

- It tells esbuild to place the resulting bundles in `app/assets/builds`, where they will be handed over to the next tool in our chain, namely Propshaft.

What esbuild actually does to the files at the top level and their included dependencies depends on its configuration, but there are default behaviors.

Identifying esbuild Default Behaviors

esbuild handles several common file types by default and with no further configuration. For example, files with `.js` endings are treated as JavaScript. (As, apparently, are `.cjs` and `.mjs`, which are unlikely to be part of our Rails app.)

Let's back up for a second to talk about what "treated as JavaScript" means. Since 2015, new features have been added to JavaScript regularly, via a standards process overseen by an organization called Ecma (you may sometimes see the language referred to as ECMAScript). Who the Ecma organization is and why it gets to run JavaScript is a different discussion; the main point here is that new proposals are made to the language, and there is a multi-stage process to evaluate them. If a proposal is successful, it eventually makes it to "stage 4." Stage 4 proposals have full specifications that are available for the browsers to implement.

Browsers don't always implement the latest changes, especially if the browser is older and wouldn't even know about newer changes. Because developers want to